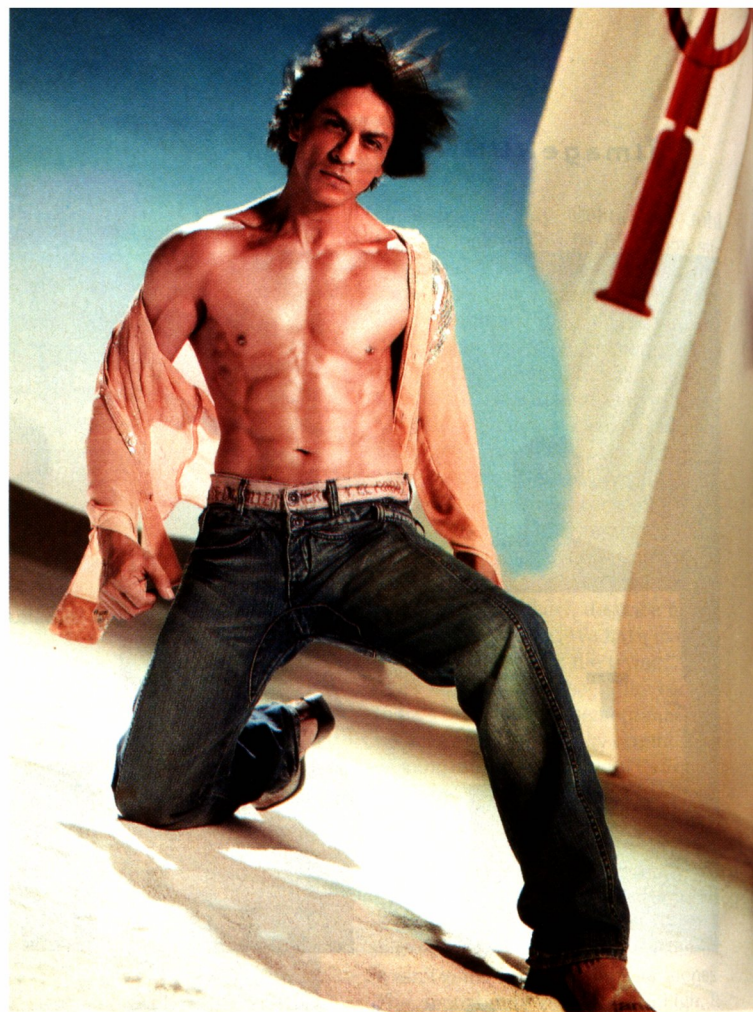


cover story CINEMA

Om. "You know, when I was growing up, my mother could only afford to buy me tickets for one match. I remember it was an India-Pakistan match where Imran Khan made 32 runs. I don't need a cricket match to promote myself but I love it that my son has the opportunity that his father can take him to cricket matches perhaps in a private plane. If my mother could afford a team for me she would have bought it. I could, so I bought it." The other trigger was his son's (Aryan, aged 10) comment to him at 2.30 one morning—in Shah Rukh Khan's world, food and sleep are rationed commodities and SMSes are responded to till 5 in the morning—that he buy a team on his own. "He told me, 'Papa, we are rulers, not servants. Let's do this alone'. I woke up my wife (Gauri) in turn and told her this. She wasn't very happy."

If Shah Rukh is an example to his colleagues (musician Vishal Dadlani says his passion is infectious), it is his children who are his inspiration. "I play hockey and soccer with them at home. I train them for running. That's why my daughter always comes first in

SIX PACK TO STICKS: Stills from the films *Om Shanti Om* and *Chak De! India* (far right)



HE HAS built his own folklore, an aspirational narrative India can identify with, of a middle-class Delhi boy, who loses his parents young, comes alone to Mumbai, says to the sea he will own it one day and does so.

Om. I think sports instill in people the habit of winning, no matter who the opposition is," he says. Often they also provide him with the best ideas, which he dashes out on his laptop in his trademark all-caps. The attention to detail is obsessive—from the buttons on the uniforms of the Kolkata Knight Riders to the 145 potential names he thought of for his team (among them were WWE-influenced gems like The Hitmen,

Anti-Matter, Ball Breakers, Dominators, Kolkata Cannons and Hangmen). Their logo, All the King's Men, is his idea as well, a play on his status as the king of Bollywood. It is a status magnified when he is taken out of context. In Kolkata, 10 guards surround his slight frame, not his customary two; a 20-ft cut-out graces the entrance of Eden Gardens and entire stands rise when he turns around

to orchestrate their applause.

Shah Rukh is hands-on with almost every aspect of his work. He has a small team that helps him—the unflappable Badwal looks after his schedule, the three Morani brothers take care of his live acts, the Red Chillies team handles ads and VFX, Sanjiv Chawla (Juhi's brother) runs the film production, while Mehta (Juhi's husband and an industrialist) is in charge of the IPL team administration. Of course, the ecosystem is entirely dependent on the actor, who is in turn a function of his movies. His last two movies have done well at the box office, generating a combined revenue of Rs 150 crore, but as his ex-

\$12.5^m
earnings from first year of buying IPL team at an annual price of \$15.5 m